

The Lantern Keeper

A novel of the harbor

by Ada Grant

Chapter 1: The Harbor Lights

The wind had a habit of changing after sunset, and Elias knew it the way other men knew the turn of the tide. He climbed the iron stairs of the old tower with a lantern in one hand and a coil of rope over his shoulder, counting each step as he had counted it since boyhood.

Below him the harbor lay quiet, its water dark and close, and the small houses along the shore appeared as a row of amber sparks. Somewhere a dog barked once and then fell silent, as if the night itself had asked for quiet.

He had made this climb ten thousand times, more or less, and every time the tower gave the same answer: one room, one lamp, one wheel of glass, and the sea waiting below like a patient audience.

The keeper's book lay open on the table by the window, its pages stiff with salt. He wrote the date, the weather, the number of ships sighted, and the hour when the light would next be turned.

Chapter 2: The Keeper's Daughter

Mira had grown up at the foot of the tower, and she knew the harbor better than anyone who merely sailed it. Her father kept the ledger of the tides, and she kept the stories that went with the names in it.

On the morning of the storm she walked the breakwater in her yellow coat, testing the wind with her face, and every boathouse door she passed was already shut against the weather.

Elias watched her from the gallery rail and thought of all the mornings he had watched her grow small, then large, then small again in the curve of the bay.

Chapter 3: North Wind

The north wind arrived before its clouds. It moved over the water in a cold flat line, flattening the swells and driving the gulls inland, and the whole town knew what it meant.

They battened the boats and the shutters and the windows while the light of the tower turned against the darkening sky, and no one spoke of the sea, as if naming it would make it louder.

When the lamp came round to the west, Elias saw a green hull riding low beyond the harbor mouth, and he knew the season had changed for good.

He wrote the sighting in the ledger with a steady hand, and then he went down the stairs to wake the one person in the town who would know what to do with it.